counter this by making friendship with Britain appear the better option than co-operation with Soviet Russia.

The second layer of Soviet foreign policy, however, was one that few in the Home government appreciated: the spread of ideology and encouragement of popular unrest as a means of undermining rival governments.[148] While there was much talk in London of the threat of invasion by Bolshevik forces in places like Persia, it was the Indian government that appeared to understand that Bolshevism spread quickest and most effectively where there was mass discontent. Thus, in the Indian government's opinion, the more Britain undermined the sovereignty of the rulers of Persia and Afghanistan by imperialistic coercion, the more it inflamed nationalist and pan-Islamist feeling, then the more likely it was that Bolshevik agitators would find a ready following in these countries. If, on the other hand, Britain treated the people of southern Asia with tact, and proved an attractive ally to the shah and emir, it had little to fear from Bolshevism. Fundamental to the Indian government's policy towards Afghanistan then, was an understanding – perhaps not explicitly verbalised but certainly apparent from its handling of the Afghan peace process – of how the Bolshevik regime functioned in its international dealings.

For Delhi, then, it was imperative that the peace negotiations with Afghanistan were handled correctly, with enough firmness to disavow the Afghan delegation of any notion of the Raj's weakness but without risking pushing them into Bolshevik arms. The Home government, however, did not share this view and from the outset Chelmsford and Hamilton Grant faced criticism from London. In June 1919, Montagu complained of having not been consulted before the viceroy had arranged the armistice, particularly as he felt that the emir's letter preceding the ceasefire had not displayed enough deference. Not only had Amanullah not apologised for his actions in causing the conflict, but he had even had the audacity to compare Britain's air raids on Afghanistan to the German bombing of London during the First World War – a reference almost designed to earn the animosity of the British government and people. Montagu was worried that the viceroy had shown himself too keen for peace and that the emir had not been properly castigated for his impudence towards the British Empire.[149] Chelmsford, nevertheless, stood by his decision to accept an armistice. He